

CHANGING THE

RULES

The billion dollar IPL with its heady, telegenic cocktail of business and glamour is set to transform the very nature of Indian cricket

■ By Sharda Ugra

On April 18, with the *ka-ching* of cash registers drowning out all other sound or sense, Indian cricket will greet its own reincarnation. A first-ever privatised, professional club league to turn domestic cricket into a marketable, profitable, tradeable commodity.

BCCI's Indian Premier League (IPL) has followed big promises with big statements, mostly financial. As a startled cricket world absorbed a 10-year \$1billion (Rs 4,000 crore) media rights deal with World Sports Group (wsg) and Sony, came the team franchise bids totalling Rs 2,894 crore. The successful franchise owners included blue chip names from business and Bollywood. In a sign that IPL may be onto something, the Murdoch empire came shop-

THE INDIAN ICONS

Tendulkar, Ganguly, Dravid and Yuvraj will play only for their home team and receive a 15-per cent premium on their salary

Yuvraj Singh (left), Sachin Tendulkar

AP PHOTO/AMAN SHARMA

AP PHOTO/AMAN SHARMA